

at medical school. He was very angry about what was happening."

The meetings in Cambridge are believed to have taken place in or around 2005. What happened over the next 18 months is still something of a mystery. Security services are investigating claims that several of the men attended "outward bound"-style camping and walking trips in Cumbria in the north-west England, in Scotland and possibly in Kent in the south-east.

Equally, several of the suspects were noticed by the security services after they made mobile phone calls

talk of an overseas 'mastermind' is now being downplayed although security services are checking reports from the US that Al Qaeda militants in Iraq may somehow be involved. A quarterly intelligence report prepared in April by the UK's Joint Intelligence Analysis Centre said that there was "no indication" of a specific threat to Britain, though it warned there was evidence "that AQ-I (Al Qaeda in Iraq) networks are active in the UK". It highlighted the determination of Abd al-Hadi, the man accused by US authorities of being Osama bin Laden's emissary to Al

from the planning to the operational phase of the scheme. He drove to the Glasgow airport in a taxi, sitting in the front seat, but did not take a flight. It was clearly a final reconnaissance. A few days later he bought a secondhand jeep for £1,720 and parked it on a suburban road in Liverpool. Police are still trying to trace the purchase of the bomb cars that were to be positioned in London and to establish where exactly they were filled with gas and petrol and wired up to mobile phones.

On June 28, Kafeel and Bilal are believed to have driven the two vehicles from Glasgow to London. Then, having positioned them to be blown up in the city centre, one under the Tiger Tiger nightclub in Haymarket, the two men returned to Glasgow, separately, in buses, taxis and trains. The two bombs were found on Friday morning. One when paramedics came to the aid of a drunk and noticed fumes pouring from one car, and the other when it was towed away by traffic wardens. The phones were meant to trigger a blast when they were called. The bombers called the car outside the nightclub twice and the one in Cockspur Street four times, but the bombs failed to detonate for technical reasons. Both the jeep bombers—Kafeel and Bilal—are believed to have driven the two car bombs into London. Once they failed to go off, they hurriedly planned the second operation so as not to be seen as failures.

Convinced, rightly as it turned out, that the police were closing in, the plotters sought out the parked jeep, allegedly filled it with gas cans purchased from a local hardware store, and set out for the airport. The police located the cab company that had provided the taxi for the reconnaissance at two in the afternoon but it was too late. The Jeep Cherokee arrived at the airport at 3.15 p.m. Sergeant Torquil Campbell and Police Constable Stewart Ferguson were chatting quietly when they saw the vehicle approaching. Pouring flames, the jeep, after being blocked by security bollards, rammed into the airport's façade. Ferguson later described how its driver—despite being engulfed in the blaze—had lunged towards him



PLAN A
Police tow away the Mercedes packed with firebombs in central London



PLAN B The flaming Jeep Cherokee at the Glasgow airport's arrival terminal

abroad or accessed jihadi websites—though they were not put under surveillance. There have even been claims that one was facing disciplinary action for the amount of time he was spending on Islamic websites while at work.

Bilal's colleagues at the Royal Alexandra Hospital were said to be deeply distressed by the news of the attacks. One doctor said the young medic was known for taking time off sick and was seen as a "bit of a slacker". Early

Qaeda in Iraq, to launch a terrorist attack in the UK "ideally" before prime minister Tony Blair's departure last month. Whether linked to an overseas 'Mr Big' or not, the conspirators stayed 'below the radar' until the very end, living very normal lives, going to football matches, travelling home for family occasions, having children and so on.

What had finally prompted the plotters into action is still unclear, but on June 13, Kafeel appears to have moved